MODULE 1 · KNOW YOUR RIGHTS

How to Vote / Whom to Vote

StreetSmarter : Because no one taught us this stuff www.streetsmarter.in

Every five years (or so), you get one small piece of paper, or one button on a machine, that decides who runs your city, your state, and your country. That's it. That's the whole trick to democracy. Nobody explains how it actually works, so here it is, in plain language.

1. Can You Vote?

You're eligible to vote in India if:

- You are 18 years old or older, on the qualifying date i.e. 1 Jan, 1 April, 1 July and 1 Oct of the year of revision of electoral roll.
- You are an Indian citizen.
- You are ordinarily resident of the part/polling area of the constituency where you want to be enrolled.
- You are not disqualified to be enrolled as an elector.
- You are registered as a voter in your constituency (the local area you live in).
- If you turned 18 recently and haven't registered yet, that's step one. Registration isn't automatic, you have to do it yourself.

2. Getting Registered

You register to vote online, through the Election Commission's own portal. Here's how:

1. Election commission of India offers online voter registration for Indian citizens who have attained the age of 18 on the qualifying date (1 Jan, 1 April, 1 July and 1 Oct of the year of revision of electoral roll)

2. Go to the National Voters' Service Portal (link below).

3. Fill Form 6, the form for first-time voters.

4. Upload a passport-size photo, proof of age (birth certificate or Class 10 marksheet), and proof of address (Aadhaar, ration card, utility bill, or similar).

5. Submit online. A Booth Level Officer may visit your home to verify your address.

6. Once approved, you'll receive your EPIC number (your voter ID number) and can download your voter ID card.

7. You can also enroll offline by filling Form 6.This form is available free of cost in offices of Electoral Registration Officers / Assistant Electoral Registration Officers and Booth Level Officers.

8. Call 1950 for any help. For more information read the Voter Brochure on https://ecisveep.nic.in/

National Voters' Service Portal · *register, check your name on the voter list, or update your details*

Voter Helpline App · *the mobile app version, works the same way*

3. Voting Day, Step by Step

1. Find your polling booth. Your voter slip or the Voter Helpline app will tell you exactly where to go.
2. Carry your voter ID card, or any accepted photo ID (Aadhaar, passport, driving licence, PAN card all work if your voter ID isn't ready yet).
3. Get your name checked off the voter list at the entrance.
4. Get a small ink mark on your finger. This shows you've already voted, so nobody can vote twice.
5. Go behind the curtain to the EVM (Electronic Voting Machine) and press the button next to the candidate of your choice.
6. Check the VVPAT screen next to the machine. It shows a paper slip for 7 seconds confirming your vote went to the right candidate.

That's it. The whole process usually takes under 10 minutes.

4. Deciding Who to Vote For

This is the part nobody teaches. Picking a candidate isn't about a poster or a party symbol you recognise. It's worth spending 20 minutes actually researching before you vote.

Ask these 5 questions about any candidate

- What has this person actually done in their last term (if they've held office before)? Look up local news, not just their own campaign material.
- Do they have any criminal cases against them? Serious criminal cases are public record, and candidates are legally required to declare them.
- What are their declared assets and income? A sudden jump in wealth between elections is worth noticing.
- What is their educational background, and does it matter to you for this role?
- What are they actually promising for your constituency, and is it realistic given what the office can control?

Tool Spotlight: MyNeta.info

MyNeta.info is a free website run by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR). It publishes candidates' own sworn declarations, the same ones filed with the Election Commission, in one searchable place.

How to use it:

- Search your constituency name or your candidate's name.
- Check the 'Criminal Cases' column, it shows the number of cases and whether any are serious (like violence or corruption).
- Check declared assets, both the candidate's and their spouse's, and compare it to what it was in their last election, if they've contested before.
- Check education and profession, listed exactly as the candidate declared it.

MyNeta.info · *search by state, constituency, or candidate name*

A Few Myths, Busted

Myth	Fact
One vote doesn't change anything.	Indian elections have been decided by fewer than 200 votes before. Close constituencies flip on small margins every cycle.
I should vote for whoever my family always votes for.	You're allowed, and encouraged, to research and decide for yourself. It's a secret ballot for a reason.
NOTA (None of the Above) doesn't count.	NOTA is a real, recorded option on the machine. It doesn't change the result, but it's a legitimate way to register that no candidate earned your vote.

5. Before You Head Out: Checklist

- ☐ My name is on the voter list (checked on voters.eci.gov.in).
- ☐ I know exactly where my polling booth is.
- ☐ I have my voter ID card or an accepted alternate photo ID ready.
- ☐ I've looked up my candidates on MyNeta.info.
- ☐ I know roughly what I care about locally, roads, water, schools, safety, so I can judge who's actually addressing it.

Useful Links

National Voters' Service Portal · *register, check or update your voter details*

Election Commission of India · *official rules, schedules, and results*

MyNeta.info · *candidate criminal records, assets, and education*

Voter Helpline App · *check status and find your booth on your phone*

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